

The Open Source WARS



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This article looks at how differences of opinions between developers and users of open source software have led to competitive battles, with some software emerging victorious and dominating over others.

Humans have a strong sense of individuality. This leads to a variety of viewpoints, even on seemingly insignificant issues. The world of computing is no better in this respect. Let me clarify the matter with a simple example. While writing a program in C, C++ or Java, where would you place the curly bracket? Many professional programmers follow one of the two styles in the code given below:

```
fun( ) {
    //Body of the function
}

foo( )
{
    //Body of the function
}
```

Then again, while writing a program, which of the following would you choose as the name of a variable to store the number of students in a class -- *numberOfStudents* (Camel case), *NumberOfStudents* (Pascal case) or *number_of_students* (Snake case)? This is yet another trivial but hotly debated matter as far as source code indentation is concerned.

These and other technical/aesthetic choices while writing programs lead to the creation of different indentation styles for source code. Some of the popular indentation styles followed by programmers include the K&R style, GNU style, Allman style, Whitesmiths style, etc.

Now let us move on to more serious stuff. Is there any such infighting going on in the open source

world? Unfortunately, the answer is 'Yes'. But does it affect open source software adoption negatively? Again, the answer is 'Yes'. It is a well-known fact that Linux or its variants like Android dominate the operating systems used in smartphones, workstations, mainframes, supercomputers, etc. However, in the personal computing space, Linux has a market share of less than 10 per cent. If Android is the most dominant among smartphone operating systems, then why can't Linux be the dominant among PC operating systems? Linux is efficient and easy to use but it doesn't dominate the PC industry. People usually opt for laptops bundled with the Windows operating system because the usage is pretty straightforward (whether the operating system is